

US Healthcare & Eyewear Guide

1. General Commercial Insurance Process

Step 1: Identify Your Plan Type & Choose a Primary Care Physician (PCP)

- **Create an Account:** Register on your insurance provider's website or app using your personal info and Member ID. Review your benefits, deductible, copays, and coinsurance.
- **Determine Plan Type:**
 - **HMO Plan:** Requires selecting an in-network Primary Care Physician (PCP). Referrals from your PCP are mandatory to see specialists.
 - **PPO Plan:** Allows direct booking with in-network specialists without a PCP referral.
- **Select a PCP:** Browse in-network providers, call to verify if they are **accepting new patients**, and schedule an initial appointment (Established Visit).

Step 2: Initial PCP Visit (Obtaining a Referral)

- **Initial Consultation:** Nurses and doctors will record your medical history, lifestyle, and medications. Clearly communicate all symptoms, desired screening tests, or specialist needs.
- **Get a Referral:** If deemed necessary, your doctor will issue a referral.
 - *Tip:* Research preferred in-network specialists before your appointment and share their details with your PCP; otherwise, the clinic may assign one.
- **Set Up Patient Portal:** Register for the health system's portal (e.g., **MyChart**) to book appointments, message providers, and view lab results.

Step 3: Wait for Insurance Approval (Prior Authorization)

- Complex imaging (e.g., MRI/CT scans) or specific specialties may require **Prior Authorization (PA)** from your insurer.
- Approval takes several business days to two weeks. Status updates are sent via email or MyChart.

Step 4: Book Your Specialist Appointment

- Once approved, locate an in-network specialist on your insurer's portal or MyChart to schedule an appointment.
- *Note:* Specialist availability is often limited; book as early as possible.

Step 5: Specialist Visit & Language Services

- **Preparation:** Bring relevant medical history, past test results, and a current medication list.

- **Interpreter Services:** You can request a free **Medical Interpreter** at check-in. Most insurance customer service lines also offer native-language support.

Step 6: Prescription & Pharmacy Management

- **Select a Pharmacy:** Provide your preferred in-network pharmacy (e.g., CVS, Walgreens, Costco Pharmacy) during your visit for electronic prescription routing.
- **Pickup Process:** Processing takes a few hours to two days. Bring your ID and insurance card to pay your copay (typically \$5–\$20).
- **Over-the-Counter (OTC) Drugs:** Non-prescription medications can be bought directly at any pharmacy. Pharmacists are available for free consultation regarding dosage and usage.

2. UC SHIP Guide for UC Students

The UC Student Health Insurance Plan (UC SHIP)—typically underwritten by Anthem Blue Cross—includes medical, dental, and vision coverage.

- **Primary Care at Student Health Center (SHC):** Non-emergency care must start at your campus SHC (e.g., UCLA Ashe Center, UCB UHS). Exceptions include Emergency Room visits, Urgent Care, OB/GYN, and select telehealth services.
- **SHC Referral for Off-Campus Care:** Off-campus specialist care requires an official **SHC Referral**. Unapproved visits will result in claim denials.
- **Break/Vacation Rules:** If you are over 50 miles away from campus during academic breaks, submit a request via the Patient Portal for an **Administrative Referral** to visit local Anthem in-network providers.

3. Eye Exam & Glasses Savings Guide

Core Money-Saving Principles

- **Separate Exam from Eyewear Purchase:** Optometrists make margins on frames. By law, providers must give you a copy of your prescription at no extra charge. Take it to buy frames online or at discount retailers.
- **Obtain Your Pupillary Distance (PD):** Request your PD during your exam. It is required for ordering glasses online.
- **Use FSA/HSA Funds:** Pre-tax funds from Flexible Spending Accounts or Health Savings Accounts can cover exams, glasses, and contact lenses.
- **Add-Ons:** High-index lenses or blue-light blocking coatings add unnecessary cost for low prescriptions (below -3.00 diopters). Basic resin lenses are sufficient.

Where to Buy Affordable Glasses

Category	Retailer	Price Range	Key Features
Online Retailers	Zenni Optical	\$7 – \$30+	Lowest prices, wide selection, 3D virtual try-on.
	EyeBuyDirect / GlassesUSA	\$20 – \$50+	Frequent BOGO deals and 50% OFF promotions; faster shipping.
Physical Store	Costco Optical	~\$70 (frames) \$130–\$150 (complete pair)	High-quality anti-reflective lenses, in-person fitting. Accepts vision insurance (VSP, EyeMed). <i>Membership required for eyewear purchase, but not for exams.</i>
Boutique Chain	Warby Parker	\$95 (complete single-vision)	Transparent pricing, stylish designs, Home Try-On program (5 free frames for 5 days). Direct copay deductions for select insurers.

Recommended Strategies

- **Budget Option (~\$100 total):** Get an exam at Costco or Walmart (\$70–\$90 out-of-pocket) Order frames online at Zenni Optical (\$15–\$30).
- **Insurance Option (\$10–\$25 copay):** Use Vision Insurance (e.g., UC SHIP vision coverage) at Costco or Warby Parker for discounted complete pairs.